The chief demand of the Assamese movement was the detection and deportation of illegal Bangladeshi immigrants. Under the Foreigner's Act of 1946, the burden fell on the accused to prove Indian nationality.[51] In 1983, in response to the agitation, a new law for Assam called the Illegal Migrants (Determination by Tribunals) Act or IMDT Act was passed, defining foreigners as those who settled in Assam after 25 March 1971, the day Pakistan began its crackdown on Bangladeshi separatists. However, the law was considered to be ineffective as the burden of proof fell on the denouncer to show someone's illegal incursion. In subsequent decades, under different political regimes, only a few thousand migrants were deported before the Act was struck down as being unconstitutional in 2005. Migration from the Hindi heartland and Bangladesh continued to persist over decades because the migrants mostly occupied low-skilled jobs which the locals didn't perform. The most recent development of the saga is the creation of the National Register of Citizens for Assam in 2017, again aimed to identify and deport illegal migrants. In a way, the Assamese experience resembles the US–Mexico immigration debate, with anti-migrant political rhetoric mixed with little on-the-ground action on immigration controls. And if the growing influence of the Spanish language is a matter of concern for the Americans, in India, the issue is communally charged because the share of the Muslim population in Assam has steadily increased from 24 per cent in 1971 to 34 per cent in 2011. To be sure, not all immigration occurs from Bangladesh, and Bihari migrants have also been caught in the crossfire of anti-migrant agitations, invoking retaliation against the Assamese travelling in trains passing through Bihar.

South of Bihar is the state of Jharkhand with a large tribal population covering the Chhota Nagpur plateau. It was created in 2001 after a long regional movement that, like Assam, traces its roots to migration in the 19th century. British colonization not only led to the mass migration of many Chhota Nagpur tribes—Munda, Oraon, Hos and others—towards the east as part of the Great Indian Migration Wave, but also brought in Bengali and Bihari labourers, administrators and professionals. With the development of coal mining, and then several mineral-based industries, there was a steady